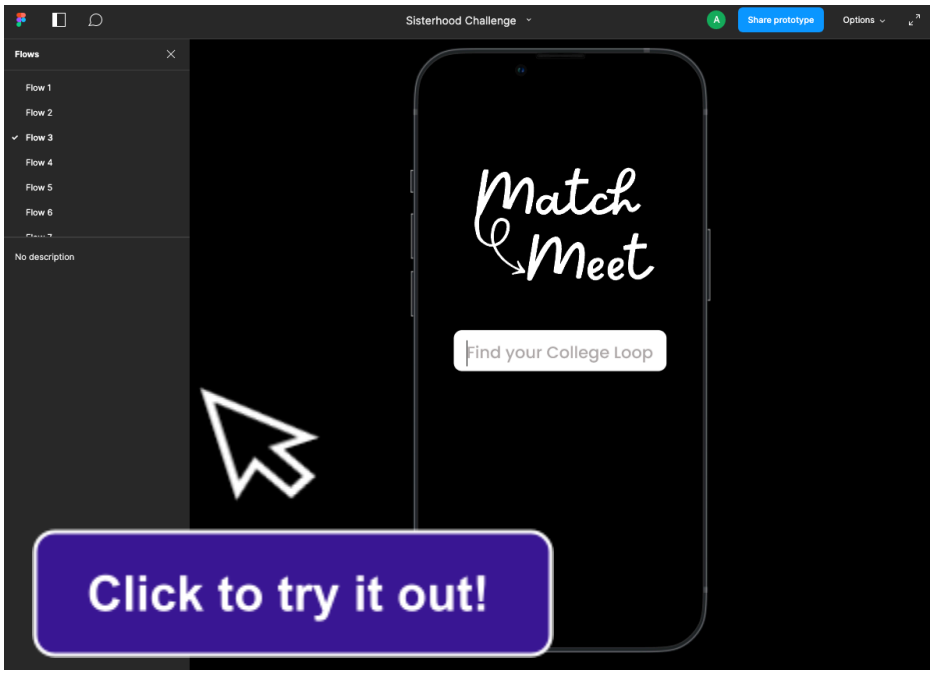
Match Meet

#BetterTogether

DEMO

2022 GirlsWhoCode - College Loops Challenge

PROTOTYPE



Feel free to also [View Full Figma Board]

CREATORS

Meet the team from GWC at UNC Charlotte Loop!



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BS Computer Science: Cyber Security

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Learn more

ABOUT THE PROJECT

Inspiration

As working college students, we both know how hard it can be to find time to connect with others. And when you do find time, there can be some challenges with finding those connections. It can be hard to make connections that will make it past a message or two.. And that's if you get a response in the sometimes never ending streams of chat channels.

It also might not be the right time for others, or it might not be the kind of connection they are looking for. For example, if you are looking for help on a specific topic or project and they are looking for a buddy to attend class or events with. Then you can end up spending the little time you do have on a connection that didn't work out for either party. We wanted to change that… enter ***Match & Meet!***

We wanted to create an app that helps people connect on specific things in one place with all of the relevant information they need or want for that connection. This way, you can show exactly what you have time for, want to do, etc., and others can connect with you based on that with a quick search! Our hope is to make more successful and long-lasting connections with other GWC Sisters in your Loop.

What it does

Match & Meet offers functionality to add information to help others find you, search for others for events, projects, interests, and skills, and ultimately, get connected! Below you can see a breakdown of how it does this.

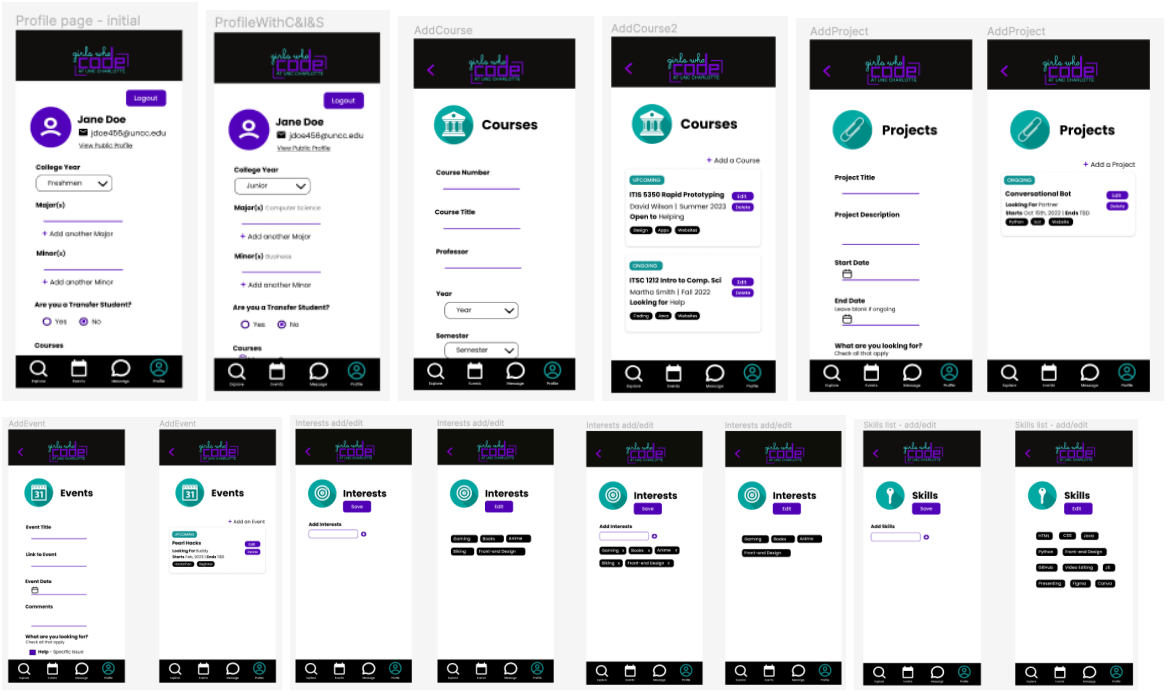
(1) Find your GWC College Loop

You can search for your College, and then login through your college's verification process. This will log you into the corresponding GWC College Loop.

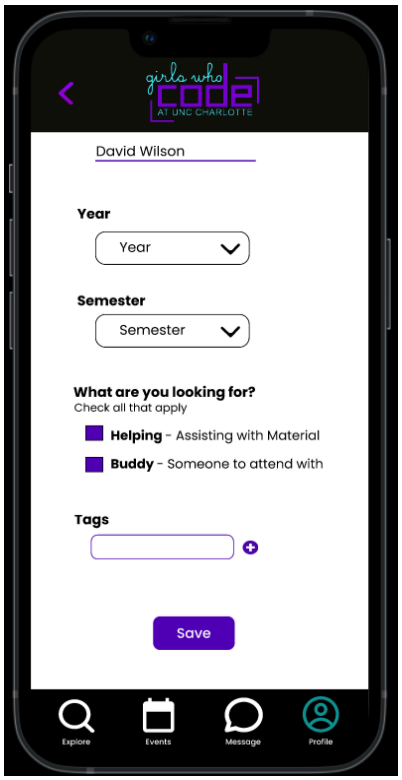


(2) Create Your Profile

Once you are logged into your GWC College Loop, you will see your name and email was pulled from your school's system. Then you can add anything to your profile that you would like others to be able to match you on. This includes: majors, minors, courses, interests, projects, skills, and events. You don't need to include any information, no matter how basic, that you aren't interested in connecting on.



In the first row, you can see the profile and adding majors, minors, courses, and projects. These utilize text boxes, dropdowns, radio buttons, and entering relevant course and project details people may need to know. Then in the second row, you can see adding events, interests, and skills. Adding events is a similar process to courses and projects, while interests and skills utilize tags that you can easily add and delete.



Courses, projects, and events all involve a key piece to supporting our matching system. That is the checkboxes for what you are open to, shown in the image to the left. Those options can change depending on what type of thing it is. For example, courses offer “Helping” and “Buddy”, while projects offer “Help” and “Partner”.

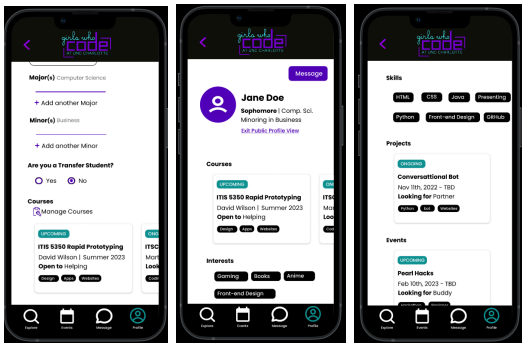
The key differences are:

- **Helping** - you are able to help someone with it
- **Help -** you need help with something specific
  (not long-term or partnership)
- **Buddy -** you want to hangout or attend together
- **Partner** - you want to team up for it

Later you will see how these are reflected in the card postings created from filling these out.

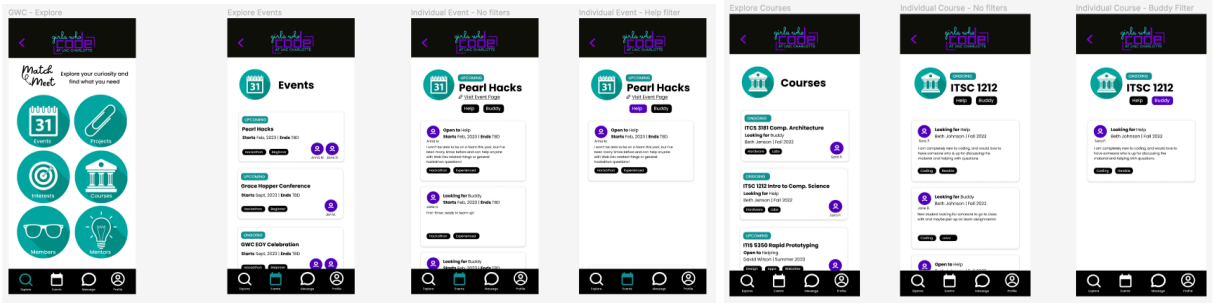
After filling out the information for a course, project, or events, you can add tags to help others find it when searching for a specific topic or tool.

Once you have saved the information, it will add these to cards for courses, projects, and events. Interests and skills will be added as tags. All of these sections can be easily side-scrolled to view and have a “manage” option if you want to edit, delete, or add more items to any particular category. You can see this below in the first image. In the next image, you can see the “Public Profile View”, that you can use to see what your profile will look like to others



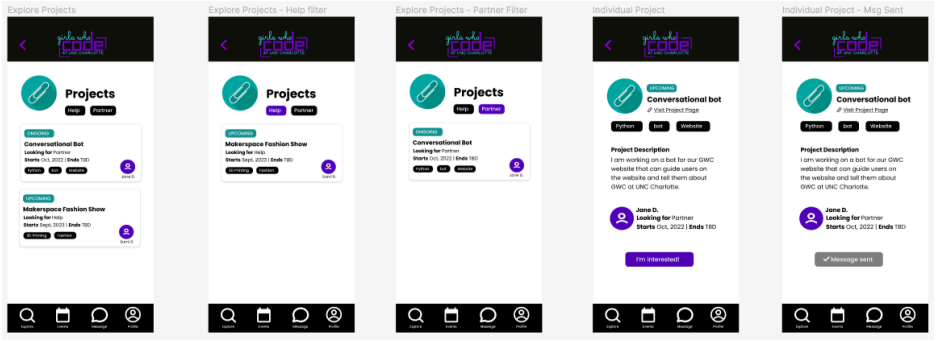
(3) Search for Connections

Match & Meet offers 6 different categories you can use to search: Events, Projects, Interests, Courses, Members, and Mentors. Each of these are shown in the first frame in the image below, and each category allows certain types of connections, of those options mentioned in the previous section. These are broken down further below.

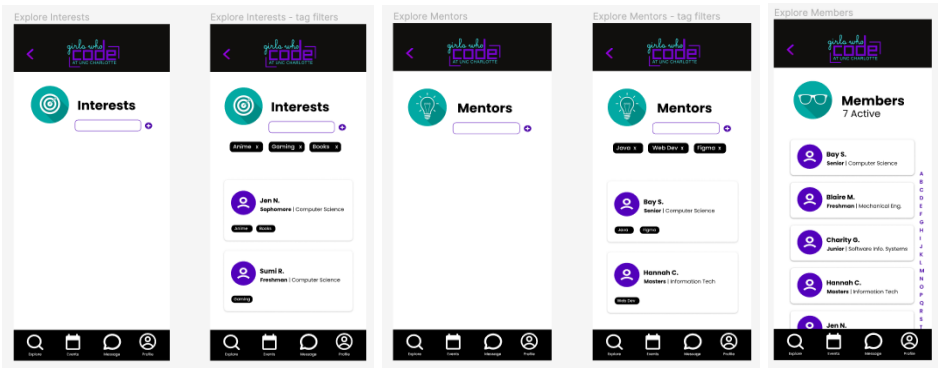


Event searches, like in the example above, list all ongoing and upcoming events in order of their start date. Then on the cards you can see “Open to” or “Looking for” labels. These indicate if someone is open to helping someone or looking for help, or they could be looking for a buddy. This works the same way for projects and courses, just with projects having “partner” instead of buddy. You can also see people who have posted about a particular event or course as little profile icons with their names. Once you click on an event or course, the posts of each of those individuals are shown, and you can see what each of them is looking for. You have the option to use the tags at the top of the page to sort for things like “Help” or “Buddy.”

Projects work a little differently than courses and events, and this is shown in the frames below. They have the option to sort based on “Help” or “Partner” tag options on the list page itself. Then, once you click a project card, it takes you to a page with all of the details on that project and has an option to directly let the person posting about the project know you are interested.

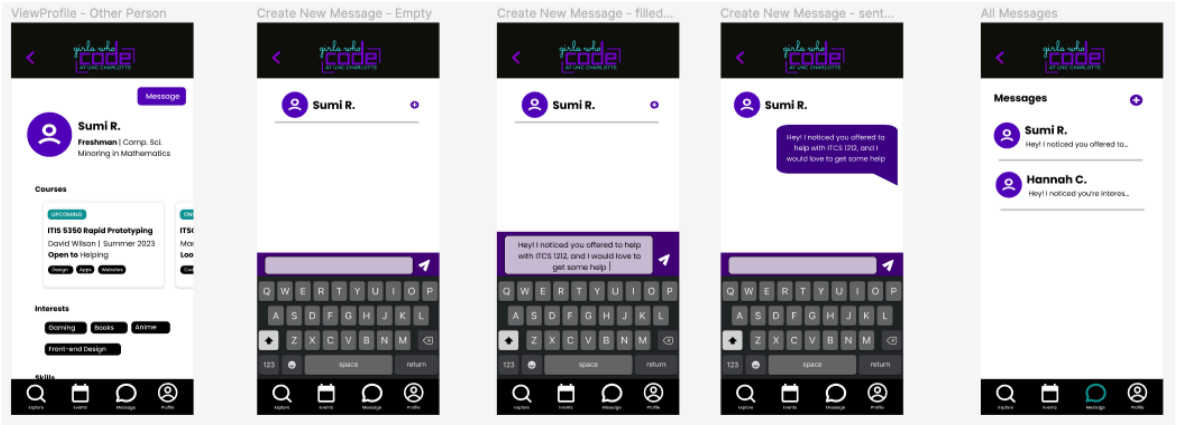


Interests and mentor searches work differently as well. They both use a tag-based search, where you can add the tags you want to find matches for. Then interest searches find matches for people's interest tags, and mentor searches find matches for people's skills. The members search allows you to see a list of all active members in your College Loop.



(4) Message Members

Now we can get connected! Once you find someone you are interested in reaching out to, you can click on their image and visit their profile. Here you can find the "Message" option and get started letting them know what you saw that you are interested in connecting on. That could be an interest, a skill, event, etc. If it was a project, then the idea was that they will receive a message that you are interested in helping or partnering on that project, and they can message you directly from that notification. That last part is a future addition, as we don't have the frames built out for that yet. However, once you message someone, you do have the option to view all your messages as well. You can see an example of messaging in the frames below.



How it solves problems

Match & Meet was created to solve two main problems connecting with others within their GWC College Loop that we felt were most commonly encountered in current connection methods like Discord. We hope to only take your attention when it is meaningful and give you the information you need to judge which opportunities are right for you. In doing this, we believe we can increase connection rates and success.

PROBLEM: Getting an answer

Anyone else post something like “Is anyone taking ITIS 1212 this semester?” And then you don’t hear anything back? People may also not want to answer if they don't know what they’re getting into. They might think things like “Why are they asking?”, “I could help with a quick question, but I don’t have much more time than that right now”, “I wonder which professor they have”, etc.

SOLUTION: Include relevant information and optional commentary in a posting.

By including relevant details for any type of connection posting, this can help you find the right people for that type of connection. We believe this, in turn, can lead to an increased number of responses by allowing users to feel empowered with understanding the situation more *prior* to reaching out. This way, when they reach out, it is more likely for them to be more invested and create a successful connection.

PROBLEM: Manage your attention efficiently

While apps like Discord have made it easier to contact people, and may even have channels for specific things, it still requires users to pay attention to these channels to find the things they want to respond to. And I think most of us can relate to how hard that can be with so many channels and notifications.

SOLUTION: Choose notifications more specifically and only search when you want to.

We allow users to only enter information and add potential connection items for what they are currently open to, and the ability to remove them when they’re not or that opportunity has passed if they no longer want to discuss that thing. This puts the user in control of what people would potentially see and want to connect on, likely limiting the number of messages they receive that are unrelated to things they’re interested in or could help with.

We also reduce the cognitive load of keeping up with long streams of (sometimes) random conversations, if you don’t have time but want to keep up with what is happening now. You no longer need to worry about missing someone saying they’re in a certain class or are attending a specific event. You can search when *you* want to, and you won’t see information that people no longer want to talk about. So you can see the current options for things when the want or need arises.

How we built it

While we are eager to build this for use and adoption across college loops, we felt the best way to start was with a plan and a prototype. And for the scope of the prototype, we focused on our own college loop here at UNC Charlotte.

Match & Meet Brainstorm

It all starts with a plan

Our team spent the first day figuring out what problems we wanted to solve in the theme of sisterhood. We brainstormed until we reached a main idea that we were excited about. Then we worked on what kinds of tasks this app could have to support the goals of that idea. Many hours were spent typing ideas into our shared doc and trying to demonstrate design options with a mouse on Zoom's whiteboard, many of which you can see in our brainstorming doc included above.

⚒️ Match & Meet Figma Board

Then it was time to build out these ideas

We both had some previous experience with Figma, and wanted to use these skills to create our vision for this app. Ashley mainly focused on page designs and building out the various wireframes, and Zaina mainly focused on the connections, effects, and interactable pieces. Each of us stepped in and helped each other when we reached issues or needed help finishing pieces in time. We complemented each other quite well in terms of what we preferred to focus on.

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Lastly, it was time to demo the prototype

Zaina worked on recording herself running through the prototype. Then she added a voice over to describe the different features and functionalities she was showing on screen. She edited these pieces together and posted an awesome demo on YouTube that you can check out above!

Challenges we ran into

Our team encountered a few challenges in this project, with the biggest being time and managing it efficiently. We were excited about the idea, and that can lead to discussions and brainstorming down many different avenues. It was hard to scope things down to a manageable size to complete within the given time frame. We were notified from our local college loop that the date was extended for this challenge 2 days before it was due. So we treated it like a weekend hackathon and had to figure out how much was possible to do within that time frame.

Something that also added a challenge was our different levels of Figma knowledge. There were many times that I (Ashley) ran into things I didn't know or did incorrectly, and we found out it wouldn't work properly for the interactive parts. In these challenges, Zaina was a huge help in mentoring me on better ways to do those things and showing me why those worked the way they did. In addition to Figma knowledge, we also had varying time frames we could work on things around our work and school schedules. But we were able to figure out how to divide and conquer around these schedules.

Accomplishments we're proud of

We were most proud of our idea and what that could mean for improving the process of connecting with other GWC Sisters. We would definitely use this if it existed. We're also proud of how many frames we were able to create in such a short time frame. And while we didn't get all of the interactions added that we wanted, we were able to get all of the main interactions to go through our user journeys for the main tasks done.

What we learned

We learned a lot about how best to work and communicate on projects that are due in such a short time frame. We were able to communicate openly about our strengths and weaknesses and learn how to apply that information when considering how to divide and conquer things. This is a skill that will definitely help with future projects. We definitely strengthened our Figma skills as well. We came across many things we didn't know we could do.

What's next for Match & Meet

We have many ideas for future enhancements, and we have listed some of the main ones below.

(1) Tutorials & Page Instructions

- Help new users with a brief tutorial utilizing pop ups and a tour of the main functionality
- Inform users what they can search for on some pages where it might not be clear

(2) Transfer Student Info

- If they answer "yes" ask when they transferred and from where
- This could help others see if they came from the same school or at the same time

(3) Partner Numbers

- Ask how many partners they're looking for when creating a project
- Have a way to label when a project team is full

(4) Tag Interactions

- Allow quick navigation based on tags
- Clicking on a tag (on any view) will take you to a list of items matching that

(5) Search Bars

- Allow more flexible searching on the different category search pages

(6) Professionals

- Have a way to add and validate professional mentors that want to partner with the college loop for their members